



Aashin Prasad

aashin.p@thehindu.co.in

At least, that was something. Amid uncertainty over the Indian Super League (ISL), a problem of the All India Football Federation's (AIFF's) making, the federation sought a face-saving exercise. It brought the season-ending Super Cup forward to open the new campaign in late



October, with the official announcement arriving only a month earlier.

Teams were guaranteed a maximum of five matches, with a month-long break before the semifinals, and a minimum of three for group-stage participants. The rewards were a trophy and a spot in next season's AFC Champions League 2, still nine months away.

Gerard Zaragoza, Bengaluru FC's former head coach who left after his team's group-stage exit, summed it up best when asked for his takeaways from the three matches.

"Punjab FC started its pre-season in July. We started on September 15. Some teams have six foreigners, some teams have zero. I mean, what's happening here? You can't control anything," a bemused Zaragoza said.

Nothing seemed ideal for what was supposed to be the premier cup competition of the domestic calendar, and the performances in the group stages reflected that.

I-League clubs Rajasthan United and Dempo SC gave a good account of themselves, with Dempo salvaging three draws against ISL sides Mohun Bagan Super Giant, East Bengal and Chennaiyin FC despite having no training in the lead-up.

Twenty-four group-stage matches were held over 13 days across two venues in Goa, the Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium and the GMC Athletic Stadium, at the tail end of the monsoon season.

The JLN Stadium in Margao, which was also hosting three FC Goa home matches in the AFC Champions

Time crunch: Mumbai City FC (left) in action against FC Goa, just over 16 hours after landing in Goa due to the IndiGo airlines crisis. AIFF MEDIA

League Two, bore the brunt of the congestion by staging an astonishing 13 matches in 16 days. The fatigue showed in the stands too, with average attendance dipping below 500 spectators per game.

The quality of the pitch deteriorated by the end of the league stage. Swathes of grass peeled off during matches, putting player safety at risk.

"You cannot play in conditions like this. For me, this is embarrassing," Kerala Blasters head coach David Catala told the host broadcaster. "This is not the image that the Indian federation has to give. This is dangerous for the players; they can get injured. They have to see... the conditions are not the best.. just with three weeks training and having to play every two days."

Then, ahead of the semifinals, the federation took evasive action that felt more reactive than planned.

When this publication asked East Bengal and Punjab FC's head coaches about the condition of the JLN pitch during the pre-match briefing, the federation's media officer skipped the questions. Only a softened version of the query was allowed, which FC Goa head coach Manolo Marquez answered.

After both semifinals and the final, access to the press conference rooms was blocked, with the briefings shifted to the mixed zone amid